

Nuke is Back

With rising oil prices and concerns about carbon emission levels, nuclear energy is enjoying a major global comeback, despite problems of storage of spent fuel and worries about accidents. It is regarded as a clean technology and a renewable energy resource. India's ambitious plan to build a substantial nuclear power base has been thwarted by the shortage of uranium and crippling technology sanctions in the past. The Indo-US deal holds hope that the country could make nuclear power a major factor in its energy calculus.



Waste Watch

Indian urban areas now generate enormous amounts of solid wastes, though the average is still low as compared to the developed world. This shouldn't make us complacent as waste recycling efforts by municipalities have met with little success given the fact that most of these are mismanaged or in debt. More innovative Public Private Partnerships (PPP) could be developed to not only dispose off the waste but also find out whether money could be earned from recycling mounds of garbage.

Building Codes

With large commercial buildings mushrooming across the country, the government launched the Energy Conservation Building Code (ECBC) in 2007. It was designed to optimise energy use in buildings. The Government estimates that if all commercial spaces conform to such norms, energy consumption in this fast-growing sector could be reduced by as much as 30 per cent.

Hydrogen Hope

Hydrogen is now being touted as the magic bullet to replace fossil fuels in the future. Several countries have been experimenting, but problems of storage and production of hydrogen persist. Prototypes for two and three-wheelers running on hydrogen have been developed but large-scale penetration will take a decade or so. India should also step up its research on hydrogen as a fuel.

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No Junkyard

Why have car junkyards? Instead, if materials like steel, aluminium and rubber are extracted from them, a sizeable amount of stuff could be reused. In the next 10 years, 1.5 million tonne of steel could be recovered from old vehicles. These would reduce mining for metals and prevent degradation of the environment.

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New Heights

Eco-friendly buildings are the latest trend in India. Companies are using recycled materials to erect structures. Air conditioners are being fitted with intelligent sensors to regulate cooling according to the number of people in the room. Double-glazed glass cuts down on energy costs both for cooling and heating. Next time you plan to build a house or set up a new office, ask your architect for a green building. You can save 30 per cent on energy costs.

Ban the Bag

The Indus Valley Civilisation left beautifully-crafted pottery that speaks volumes of the advances its people made. After 3,000 years, if the ruins we leave behind are excavated, chances are only plastic bags would be dug up. It may sound like an exaggeration, but these bags are not biodegradable. Apart from causing emissions when these are manufactured, noxious fumes are released while these are being burnt or disposed off.



AP PHOTO/TATAN SYUFLANA

So, be kind to Mother Earth the next time you go shopping for groceries, remember to carry your cloth bag with you.



Computers Off

Most people think that allowing your computer to hibernate or go into screensaver mode means they are saving on energy. But, you would be surprised to know it does consume power and also increases carbon emissions. It is best to switch it off if you do not plan to use it for a few hours.